WHY PMIS HAS FAILED TO CLICK

A feedback survey of candidates by the MCA threw up several reasons, as did a back-check by a leading FMCG company of candidates from the first phase. If the MCA's survey revealed that candidates were discouraged by distant locations, the longer internship period than in other skilling programmes and uninteresting roles, the FMCG firm's survey echoed those findings: 32 per cent said they were looking for a full-time role, 22 per cent didn't like the sales profile and wanted an office job, 18 per cent felt the location was too far, 15 per cent were pursuing higher education, and 13 per cent said the one-year internship duration was too long and they could commit only for a month or two. Disaggregated, these are some of the chief reasons why the PMIS has failed to take off.

LOCATION: This emerged as a chief deal-breaker, with candidates preferring their workplace to be within 5-10 km of their place of residence. Women especially often face constraints in relocating to cities far from their villages, says Isha Gupta, research lead at the research firm JustJobs Network.

LOW STIPEND: Experts feel the initial internship stipend of Rs 5,000 a month is too small and not attractive enough for the youth to consider it. Back home, they can often earn more through odd jobs or MGNREGA employment. Given their family background, Gupta explains, the expectation is to earn from day one and also send money back home. "For these youth, it is about making ends meet today," she says. "They don't have the privilege or the foresight to see an internship as a gateway for better opportunities."

PERMANENT Vs TEMPORARY, PRIVATE Vs SARKARI JOB: Speaking from their experience of working with thousands of candidates across sectors, Aditya Narayan Mishra, MD & CEO of HR services firm CIEL HR, reveals how many graduates treat "temporary job offers as backups while they look for more permanent roles". This is probably because most of the target candidates are from underprivileged backgrounds, and are looking for a full-time job rather than a temporary internship. Ideally, they would like a government job, which they consider more secure. Hence, the better uptake for PSU internships. ONGC rolled out 6,000 internship positions in the first pilot and another 4,200 in the second. Recounting their company's altogether different experience, the CHRO of a diversified conglomerate laments: "We rolled out 269 offers for a target of 259 hires, but only 32 joined. Today, just nine remain. The socio-cultural aspect wasn't taken into account, which is why the uptake is so low."

WHAT IS THE PM INTERNSHIP SCHEME?

The design, deficiencies and desirable solutions for the programme

THE SCHEME

Announced in the 2024-25 Budget, PMIS aims to provide 12 months of industry exposure to 10 million youth in top 500 companies in five years to improve their employability

ELIGIBILITY

Youth between the ages of 21 and 24 years, who are not studying full-time, are not employed full-time and no one in their family holds a government job or earns more than Rs 8 lakh per annum

WHO IS EXCLUDED?

Graduates from top schools (IITs, IIMs, NLU, IIITs etc.); holders of professional or higher degrees (CA, CMA, CS, MBBS, MBA, Master's etc.); enrolled in any central or state government apprenticeship, skill, or training scheme

REMUNERATION

A monthly stipend of Rs 4,500 from the government; additional stipend of at least Rs 500 per month from the employer; Rs 6,000 one-time grant from the government; insurance cover under PM Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana and PM Suraksha Bima Yojana; internship certificate

WHAT AILS PMIS

- Lack of communication, awareness, guidance for candidates. No third-party involvement in taking them through the process. As a result, candidates often miss the fact that the job may require relocation or, say, involve standing up to 8 hours a day
- Women often averse to relocation
- Candidates seek a permanent, preferably government, job, which offers them more security
- Rs 5,000 stipend too little, candidates can earn more doing odd jobs back home, or through MGNREGA wages
- Eligibility criteria, too, are restrictive, narrowing the pool considerably